EDITED & CURATED BY
PATRICIA OKO

FROM THE MARGINS TO THE MAIN STREAM

Women Who Claimed Their Seat at the Table of Technology

The stories in this book are shared with the consent of the contributors. Every effort has been made to accurately represent each contributor's experience.

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For every woman who was told she did not belong

This book is proof that you always did.

To the woman reading this right now, whether you are just starting out, somewhere in the middle, or blazing trails at the top. You are not a coincidence. You are the pattern-breaker the world has been waiting for.

This book is also dedicated to the women who came before us, those who were never given a platform, whose brilliance went unrecorded, and whose sacrifices quietly paved the road we walk on today.

And to the next generation: the girls in classrooms across Africa who will one day build, code, lead, and transform the world. We wrote this so you would know this seat has always been yours.

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MAKING IT HAPPEN!

Patricia Oko
WTM Ambassador

There is a particular kind of courage that does not announce itself. It does not arrive with fanfare. It shows up quietly in the decision to apply for a job you have been told is not for you, in the choice to stay when every instinct says leave.

The women in this book carry that courage. Their stories are different in setting, in the specific shape of the obstacles they faced but they are united by something essential: the refusal to accept that technology was not for them.

From the Margins to the Mainstream was born from a simple conviction: that African women in tech have stories worth telling, and that those stories deserve to be heard far beyond the rooms where they happened.

Rooted in Africa and reaching across the globe, this collection is our contribution to rewriting a narrative that has for too long left us out.

To every woman whose story appears in these pages - thank you for your trust, your honesty, and your willingness to let others see themselves in you. You are not the exception. You are the beginning of a new normal.

FOREWORD

IF YOU ARE HOLDING THIS BOOK

By Cynthia Ukaegbu

Chidinma Christabel Ukaegbu

If you are holding this book, there is a good chance that somewhere along your journey, you have wondered whether you truly belong in the tech industry. Whether you are a student considering your first step into the field, already working in tech and still finding yourself as the only woman in the room, or perhaps someone who believes deeply that more diverse voices must shape the future of technology.

Whoever you are, this book was written with you in mind.

Across Africa and around the world, women are entering the tech industry in growing numbers, yet the path into these spaces has rarely been straightforward. Many women continue to navigate places where they are under-represented, underestimated, or expected to prove themselves over and over again.

Like many others, my journey into tech was not a straight line. I studied communications engineering and initially explored several paths within the tech ecosystem before eventually discovering my place in product design. Each pivot came with uncertainty, but also with a conviction that there was room for me somewhere in this industry, even if the path was not immediately clear.

Over the past six years in product design, I have experienced moments that many women in this field will recognize. Sitting in rooms where I was one of only a few women, navigating environments where I felt underestimated or expected to constantly prove myself. Experiences like these teach you that belonging is not always automatically given; sometimes, it is something you have to claim.

But alongside those challenges, I have also experienced things that are profoundly encouraging: the power of resilience, community and, of course, mentorship.

> ***"When one woman rises, she often creates space for many others to rise with her."***
>
> Chidinma Ukaegbu

Over the years, I have also had the opportunity to mentor about a hundred aspiring designers and professionals as they transition into tech. Watching someone move from uncertainty to confidence is one of the most powerful reminders that progress is rarely individual.

Breaking the pattern means refusing to accept the idea that things must remain the way they have always been. It means questioning outdated assumptions about who builds technology, who leads innovation, and whose ideas shape the digital tools that people use every day.

The women in this book have done exactly that. When you read their stories, you may recognise something of yourself in them.

My hope is that every reader will walk away with a renewed sense of possibility, because the future of technology should be shaped by people from different backgrounds, experiences, and perspectives.

Let's get reading.

Chidinma Ukaegbu

EDITOR'S NOTE

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

By Patricia Oko, WTM Ambassador

There is a kind of erasure that happens quietly. It is not always violent or sudden. Sometimes it is a conference panel with no women on it. Sometimes it is a funding round where no one asks for her pitch deck. Sometimes it is a classroom where the teacher calls on every hand but hers. Sometimes it is just the invisible wall of 'you don't quite fit here' - a wall that has no sign, no door, and no apology.

This book was born from a refusal to accept that erasure.

From the Margins to the Mainstream is a collection of stories about real African women across the globe who looked at the spaces in technology where they were not expected, not invited, and sometimes not wanted, and walked in anyway. They debugged systems that were never designed with them in mind. They pitched to rooms that doubted them. They built companies with shoestring budgets and unshakeable vision. They mentored others when no one had mentored them.

Every chapter opens with context and closes with a reflection prompt because we believe reading these stories should not just inspire you, it should move you to action.

"Breaking the pattern is not a moment. It is a daily act of choosing yourself, your vision, and your right to take up space."

These are not exceptional women in the sense of being rare. They are exceptional in the sense of being extraordinary and the extraordinariness was always there. What they needed was a room that would not diminish it. A book. A platform. A yes.

With gratitude and fire,

Patricia Oko

CHAPTER ONE

THE PIVOT

When She Changed Everything

There is a particular kind of courage required to change direction. Not the courage of someone who has nothing to lose, but the courage of someone who has everything invested in one path and chooses, deliberately, to walk another. The women in this chapter made pivots. Some were gradual, others were sudden. But what unites them is not how they pivoted. It is that they did.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

Godsfavour Ezeliora . Research Business Analyst . Westgate Group

Mmesoma Stella Nzeribe . Frontend Engineer

Madubueze Gloria Ifeoma . Frontend Engineer . LuxNet Ltd.

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Godsfavour Ezeliora

Research Business Analyst,
Westgate Group Nigeria

THE PIVOT

I have always wanted to be different things. At some point, I wanted to be a banker; in university, I wanted to be a lecturer. I did not ever think I was going to end up in tech or even build a career there. But life has a way of redirecting you when you least expect it.

At the time, I was in university, and we were on an ASUU strike. No one knew how long it would last, and I did not want to waste that time doing nothing. I also knew I was not particularly "handy." I am not someone who is naturally handy with skills, but I knew I couldn't just sit still.

Around that same period, Paystack was acquired by Stripe, and the news was everywhere. I was on Twitter, and people kept talking about how tech opens doors, the different career paths within it, and the opportunities available globally. That was the first time I became really curious.

That curiosity led me to frontend development. I started with frontend development. It was my first real look behind the curtain of how things are built.

At first, it was just about learning something new. I did not have a clear roadmap or long-term plan; I was just exploring. But as time went on, I started taking it more seriously. I joined developer communities and clubs, surrounded myself with people who had the same goals, and slowly began to understand what it meant to grow in tech.

Eventually, school resumed, and I had to pause because I needed to focus on finishing my degree.

After I graduated, I returned to tech, this time with full focus. I committed fully to learning, joining programs, and improving my skills. That phase of my journey came with a lot of trial and error.

Looking back now, I realize I made some mistakes. I was more focused on getting into programs than actual building. If I could go back, I would focus more on building projects, hands-on experience, hackathons, and practical work, because that is where the real learning happens.

Still, that phase was not wasted.

"I was not always sure where I belonged in tech. But I showed up anyway, and that made all the difference."

Eventually, frontend development got me my first role at an Edtech startup, where I worked for two years and even became a lead. That experience was valuable, but it also brought clarity. During that time, I realized I did not enjoy frontend as much as I thought I would.

That realization forced me to pause and rethink my path. I was also thinking about the amount of time I had spent in frontend, and I was struggling to tell people because I did not want to look confused.
I started researching other areas in tech and became interested in product management and data analysis. I applied for scholarships and was fortunate to receive a full scholarship to study product management and a partial scholarship for data analysis.

I have always believed in doing things that increase my surface luck; that is why every opportunity to learn, I take. No hesitation, so I completed both programs.

But along the way, I discovered I enjoyed data analysis more. Within a year, I was not just learning; I was building projects, gaining hands-on experience through internships, and applying for roles in data, practicing consistently, and growing more confident in my skills.

I also collaborated with Nexo Girls, where I taught beginners how to build their first project in data analysis, reaching over 100 people across Africa. This was also my way of giving back to the community. This project was deeply personal for me because I remembered the confusion of starting out.

The whole experience meant a lot to me.

I landed my current role as a Research Business Analyst. In this role, I get to work on a variety of exciting projects. I am currently working on an e-commerce project, and what makes this even more exciting is that I am able to combine everything I have learned, my background in development, my understanding of product management, and my skills in data analysis in the projects I work on.

Looking back, my journey has not been linear. It has been filled with pauses, pivots, and plenty of uncertainty.

But every stage mattered.

From starting out during a strike to learning frontend to realizing it was not for me to finding my place in data, each step shaped who I am today. I was not always sure where I belonged in tech.

But I showed up anyway, and that made all the difference.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Godsfavour is a research business analyst and an advocate for data literacy across Africa. With a background in business education, a nanodegree in data analytics, and currently pursuing an MBA, she specializes in turning complex datasets into actionable business strategies. She has a strong passion for community, having mentored aspiring data analysts and volunteers as a data community manager at NexaScale.

When she isn't building dashboards, she is likely reading a book or recording an episode for her podcast, Wine & Books, where she explores fiction.

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Mmesoma Stella Nzeribe
Frontend Engineer

THE PIVOT

My journey into technology did not follow a linear path, and it certainly did not come with everyone's blessing.

When I finished secondary school, most of my peers were heading into medicine and nursing, the paths people celebrated, the ones that made parents proud at family gatherings. I chose differently. I chose Computer Science. Not because it was the safe choice, but because technology had fascinated me long before I understood what a career in it even looked like.

As a child, I would stare at phones and laptops and ask questions nobody around me seemed to care about. *How does a phone actually work? What happens behind the screen? How do these apps know what to display on screen after each press?* That curiosity became the quiet compass that pointed me toward tech when it was time to decide.

What I did not anticipate was how loud the opposition would be.

After my UTME results, the comments started. "You are wasting a strong score on an easy course." "Someone as intelligent as you wants to study Computer Science?" Those were the public ones. At home, the words cut differently. As a girl, I was told that programming is for men, that programmers live in isolation, and that I would lose my social life, my personality, and my connection to the world around me.

> *"The pivot was never just about choosing technology. It was about choosing myself. And that made all the difference."*

As ironic as this may sound, the more I heard it, the more certain I became. I refused to let other people's fears become my limitations.

In 2023, after secondary school, my father enrolled me in coding classes. I started with HTML, then CSS, then JavaScript. Later, I took PHP and MySQL classes. But it was frontend development where something clicked. There is a specific kind of joy in writing code and watching it transform, visually, into something real. Something people could see and interact with. That feeling kept me going.

University came and brought its own weight. My first year was overwhelming, and I stepped away from coding for a stretch. But I came back. I always come back. I now build my skills through self-directed learning and mentorship. I have learned that this unstructured, self-driven path is its own kind of discipline.

Ultimately, I have come to understand that growth in software development is not one big breakthrough. It is small, consistent steps taken even when progress feels invisible. There were real moments of doubt. Times I questioned whether I was technical enough, smart enough, or simply meant for this field. But I kept learning. I kept building. And slowly, what changed was not just my skill set. It was my sense of what I was capable of.

The compound effect of steady learning is real. Every concept I struggled with and finally understood, every project I pushed through when it was frustrating, every line of code I rewrote until it worked, all of it added up. My confidence grew alongside my competence, and the two kept feeding each other.

And those predictions I heard about my social life? None of them came true. I socialize. I lead teams. I organize events. I connect with people locally and internationally because I do not want to be a developer who only writes code. I want to be a developer who thinks for people, whose work carries a human dimension.

Exposure was another factor that shaped me early, too. At eleven, I represented my school at the Nigerian Turkish (now Tulip) International College Mathematics Competition. It posed as my first real glimpse of how wide the world was and how much was possible for someone like me.

I was offered a full scholarship, but the insurgency in 2016 made it impossible to accept. I grieved it briefly, but I kept moving.

That forward motion has since taken me places my younger self could not have imagined. I received the Distinguished Leader Award from Harvard Women Engineers Code (WECode), the world's largest student-run conference. I am an active member of Rewriting the Code, and I contribute to student communities, including She Code Africa UNN, Google Developer Group on Campus UNN, Women Techmakers Nsukka, and Blockchain UNN.

I share all of this not to impress, but to reach the girl standing at the same crossroads I once stood at, being told she is too much, too soft, too female for this field. You are not! And you do not have to do this alone. I did not get here in isolation. I got here through communities, mentors, and people who believed in me before I had the proof.

As Oprah Winfrey said, *"Life has dreamed a dream for you, and your number one job is to figure out what that dream is and align yourself with it."*

The pivot was never just about choosing technology. It was about choosing myself. And that made all the difference.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Nzeribe Mmesoma Stella *is a frontend developer and Computer Science student at the University of Nigeria, Nsukka. Since starting her coding journey in 2023, she has grown through self-directed learning and mentorship, specialising in frontend development. She is an active member of global and local tech communities, including Rewriting the Code, GDGoC UNN, Women Techmakers, SCA UNN, and Blockchain UNN, and was recognised with the Distinguished Leader from Harvard WECode.*

She is passionate about building technology with a human dimension and advocating for greater inclusion of women in the technology ecosystem.

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Madubueze Gloria Ifeoma

Frontend Engineer & Tech Leader, LuxNet Ltd

THE PIVOT

If someone had told me a few years ago that I would end up building a career in technology and helping others enter the tech space, I probably would not have believed them.

Ironically, I studied Computer Science at the university, but I never really wanted to pursue anything related to tech. My dream at the time was very different. I wanted to play volleyball professionally. That was the future I imagined for myself.

Even when my friends encouraged me to join them in learning tech, I always avoided it. They would invite me to attend training or tech meetups, but I would decline. I simply did not see myself in that world.

Then one day, something changed.

I attended a tech event where I listened to people from completely different fields talk about their success in technology. Some of them were from medical backgrounds and other non-technical courses. As they spoke, they confidently explained how they were building careers and making money in tech.

As I sat there listening, a thought kept repeating in my mind.

"*How are people from other fields coming into tech and thriving, while I am studying Computer Science and not even interested in it?*"

That moment stayed with me long after the event ended.

When I returned home that day, I looked at my laptop. I had always owned one, but I mostly used it for watching movies. It suddenly felt like I had been wasting an opportunity.

So I made a decision. I cleared the movies from my laptop and downloaded the tools I needed to start learning, VS Code and other resources that would help me begin coding. It felt like a small step, but it marked the beginning of a new direction in my life.

Shortly after, I discovered a beginner bootcamp organized by Blockchain UNN, now known as Web3Bridge. The bootcamp was designed for people who were new to tech, so I decided to join.

That decision changed everything.

During the bootcamp, my curiosity grew rapidly. I asked questions, practiced regularly, and tried to understand how things worked. For the first time, technology felt exciting instead of intimidating.

Not long after the bootcamp, I saw an opportunity for a laptop giveaway. Even though I already had a laptop, it was not in

great condition. The battery overheated, and the system struggled to keep up with the work I wanted to do.

At first, I ignored the opportunity. Later, I saw the application link again. That second time, I felt strongly that I should apply.

So I did.

When I was selected, I traveled from Lagos to Enugu to attend the event. I returned home with a brand-new laptop. At the time, I did not fully realize how important that moment would become in my journey.

Around that same period, I also came across a hackathon organized by She Code Africa. I have always been an active member of communities, so I was part of a group chat where people were discussing the hackathon and looking for one more teammate.

I told them I could contribute, especially with CSS, and they welcomed me into the team. We worked together, conducted research, and built our solution. In the end, our team finished as the second runner-up. That moment was unforgettable because it was the first money I ever earned from tech.

But life had one more twist waiting for me. Around the same time I was beginning to take tech seriously, an opportunity came up for me to represent my school as part of the volleyball team in a competition in Russia. Volleyball had always been my dream, so when that opportunity came, I did not hesitate.

I packed up all my tech materials and shifted my full focus back to volleyball.

Traveling to Russia to represent my school was an incredible experience. For a moment, it felt like I was living the dream I had always imagined. But when we returned to Nigeria, reality began to set in. The financial reward for the effort and travel was not as encouraging as I had expected.

That experience became a turning point for me.

I realized that while volleyball had been a passion, technology was beginning to offer me something different a path where I could build, grow, and create opportunities not just for myself, but for others as well.

So I made another important decision.

> *"Sometimes the decision that changes your life starts with something as simple as opening your laptop and trying."*

Between the hackathon win and receiving that laptop, I began to feel like maybe technology was where I belonged.

That decision became the pivot that changed everything. As I continued learning and growing, I began thinking about how I could create similar opportunities for others. That mindset led me to run for the position of President of NACOS (Nigeria Association of Computing Students) in my department at the University of Nigeria, Nsukka.

My goal was simple: I wanted students to experience the real, practical side of technology. I wanted NACOS activities to inspire students to explore tech beyond the classroom.

This time, I decided to fully commit to tech.

That vision led me to organize my first tech event. Before hosting that event, I made a promise to myself. Every tech event I organized would include laptop giveaways. The reason was simple. The laptop I received from an event changed my life, and I believed giving someone a laptop could change theirs too.

During that event, we gave out three laptops to students. It was one of the most fulfilling moments of my journey.

Later, I went on to become the first female President of NACOS UNN and the first

female Zonal Coordinator of NACOS Southeast. In those roles, I continued organizing tech events and creating opportunities for students through laptops, scholarships, mentorship, and learning initiatives.

Looking back today, I realize that my journey into tech was not a straight line. It included pauses, doubts, and unexpected turns. But that pivot the moment I chose to fully commit to tech changed everything.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Madubueze Gloria *Ifeoma is a Frontend Developer, community builder, and tech leader passionate about creating opportunities for young people in technology. She began her tech journey after discovering the power of digital skills to transform lives and has since dedicated herself to learning, building, and mentoring others. Gloria has organized multiple tech events and initiatives that provide students with access to laptops, scholarships, and learning opportunities. She is the first female President of NACOS UNN and the first female Zonal Coordinator of NACOS Southeast.*

Her mission is to make technology more accessible and inspire the next generation of African innovators.

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Eno Peters

Technical Product Manager

THE PIVOT

If you had asked me years ago whether I would end up working in technology, building digital products and collaborating with engineers, I probably would have said No.

My journey did not begin in tech. It began in a Physics classroom. I studied Physics at the University of Jos. Like many students in science, I was fascinated by understanding how things worked. Physics taught me to see the world through systems, forces interacting, patterns emerging, and problems broken down into smaller pieces that could be analyzed and solved.

But sometime during my third year in university, something shifted. During our industrial training period, we had the opportunity to step outside the classroom and explore more practical environments. While many of my peers followed paths closely related to our field, I found myself increasingly curious about technical spaces where things were actively being built.

I spent time around workshops and engineering environments on campus, watching people test ideas, fix things, and create solutions in real time. What fascinated me wasn't just the machines or the tools, it was the process of building.

The ability to take an idea, experiment with it, and eventually turn it into something useful.

That experience planted a quiet question in my mind: *What if I could do this too?*

At the time, I had no clear roadmap. I wasn't studying computer science, and I didn't fully

understand the technology industry. From the outside, tech felt like a space reserved for people who had been coding for years or who followed a very specific academic path.

But curiosity is powerful. Once it takes root, it keeps pushing you to explore.

After graduating, I began intentionally learning more about technology and digital products. I paid attention to the apps and platforms people used every day and started asking deeper questions: *Who builds these products? How do ideas become real platforms used by thousands or even millions of people?*

That exploration eventually led me to product management. For the first time, everything made sense.

Product management sits at the intersection of technology, business, and people. It is the role responsible for turning ideas into products by working with engineers, designers, and stakeholders to solve real problems for users.

What surprised me the most was how much my background in Physics actually helped.

Physics trains you to think critically, analyze systems, test assumptions, and approach problems logically. Those same skills turned out to be incredibly valuable when building and managing digital products.

The transition was not always easy. Walking into the tech industry without a traditional computer

science background can feel intimidating. There were moments when I had to learn quickly, ask questions, and trust that I could grow into the space.

But over time, I realized something important: your background does not have to match the industry perfectly for you to succeed in it.

Sometimes the skills you develop in one field become the foundation that allows you to thrive in another.

> *"Your background does not have to match the industry perfectly for you to succeed in it. Sometimes the skills you develop in one field become the foundation that allows you to thrive in another."*

Today, I work as a Technical Product Manager, helping to build and improve digital platforms that solve real-world problems. My work involves translating complex technical systems into products that people can easily use and benefit from.

One of the areas that excites me the most is the evolving role of artificial intelligence in product development. Technology is advancing quickly, and we are entering a time where ideas can move from concept to working prototype faster than ever before.

For someone who once wondered how to enter the technology industry, being part of that transformation feels incredibly meaningful.

Looking back, my journey into tech was not a straight line.

It was a pivot.

A decision to follow curiosity instead of staying within the boundaries of what I initially studied. A willingness to step into unfamiliar spaces and learn along the way.

And if there is one message I hope other women take from my story, it is this:

You do not have to start in technology to build a career in it.

You do not need the perfect background or the perfect plan.

Sometimes the most important step is recognizing the moment when your curiosity begins pointing you in a new direction and having the courage to follow it.

Because sometimes, changing everything begins with one simple decision: choosing to try.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Eno Peters is a Technical Product Manager based in Abuja, Nigeria. She works at the intersection of technology, strategy, and product development, building digital solutions that solve real-world problems across sectors such as agriculture, mobility, and artificial intelligence. Passionate about translating complex systems into user-friendly products, she collaborates with cross-functional teams to turn ideas into impactful platforms. Eno is also committed to inspiring more Africans, especially women, to explore opportunities in technology and innovation.

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Jessica Eze
Data Analyst

THE PIVOT

I was studying combined biology science (Biochemistry and Zoology), one I saw as a direct ticket to nowhere. I just knew I was studying UNEMPLOYMENT. In Nigeria, a pure science degree without postgraduate plans or family connections often meant stacking CVs that vanished into black holes.

I'd fought hard to escape it: rewriting JAMB again and again, scoring high enough in the last one for Nursing Science, only to slam into the tiny admission quota. Each denial felt like proof I wasn't meant for more. I had quietly given up.

The year 2022 changed me,I moved in with a friend , i did not get hostel so I squatted with her, and that's where I met her—my roommate, a loud techie who believed that tech was her path and future and never gave up, She didn't just preach; she just lived it. One night, as I vented about jobless futures and wasted years ,"*Why not try tech*?" she asked simply. "*Your biology background - experiments, messy chemistry lab results(I was always complaining about chemistry practicals), that's basically what data analysis is. You already think like an analyst."*

I simply laughed at the thought of it. In my head, it was all men coding, complex algorithms, and no room for someone like me. A well-meaning church brother later reinforced the doubt: "*My sister, forget software engineering. Too tough and mostly for male. Try video editing - it's creative, women-friendly.*" Maybe he was right. Maybe some doors stayed shut for women from backgrounds like mine. But my roommate kept nudging and sharing free Coursera links, Google Data Analytics courses, YouTube SQL tutorials. She told her own story: no fancy degree in view, she was studying chemistry education, just persistence.

> *"Pivots aren't betrayals of your past; they're expansions. One bold step, one believer, and the trajectory shifts."*

Curiosity cracked my resistance. I started with Excel pivots, basic SQL queries. The road was rough. Final year loomed while I juggled online modules. Friends asked why I bothered with "*irrelevant*" skills, why not start a business they suggested.

During the night I was always frustrated during debugging sessions while learning Python, I cried tears when it seemed as if I was not learning. But I was so happy when I made a dashboard that actually told a story. Rejection after rejection tested me, but one day an email arrived - a major data analysis internship. Turning raw business numbers into clear insights that shaped decisions.

My degree wasn't wasted after all .That one shared room, one conversation, one woman who saw potential I couldn't, changed my path. Tech isn't a locked boys' club. Data analysis, product, design, engineering - women belong everywhere, not just "*friendly*" corners. If you're staring at a degree that feels like a dead end, know this: pivots aren't betrayals of your past; they're expansions. One bold step, one believer, and the trajectory shifts.

CHAPTER REFLECTION

Is there a pivot you have been delaying?

What is the first small step you could take this week? Who in your circle has made a bold change you have never fully acknowledged? How can you encourage them or ask them to encourage you?

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Jessica Eze *is a data analyst who helps e-commerce brands generate insights and make greater sales. She has over five years of experience in data analytics and is passionate about helping young people start, navigate, and pivot their careers in tech.*

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CHAPTER TWO

THE ONLY ONE

Navigating Rooms Not Built for Her

She has been in that meeting. The one where she speaks and no one responds, and then a man says the same thing three minutes later and the room erupts in agreement. Being the only woman in a room is not a badge of honour, it is a structural failure. But the woman in this chapter did not wait for the structure to fix itself. She showed up, stayed and changed the temperature of the room by being in it.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

Mojisola Alegbe . Software Engineer . Jhool .

06

Mojisola Alegbe

Software Engineer, Jhool

THE ONLY ONE

The first time it happened, I didn't think much of it.

It was my first week studying Computer Science at university. I walked into the lecture hall early that morning, carrying a notebook and my new hand bag. The room slowly filled with students finding seats, introducing themselves, settling in for the semester.

As I sat down, I started noticing something.

Everywhere I looked, left, right, behind me, I saw the same thing, Men.

Rows and rows of young men. I scanned the room again, almost instinctively, expecting to see at least one other woman somewhere in the crowd. But there wasn't.

I was the only girl in the class.

At that moment, it felt small, almost insignificant. But over the weeks that followed, I began to feel what it really meant.

When lecturers asked questions and I raised my hand, I sometimes felt eyes turn toward me not because of what I said, but because of who was saying it. During group assignments, there were moments of hesitation before someone said, "You can join our group."

No one was openly unkind. But there was a quiet awareness that I was different. And sometimes that difference made me question myself.

I remember nights sitting with my laptop, staring at lines of code that refused to work, wondering if maybe everyone else understood something I didn't. When you're the only one who looks like you in a room, it's easy to start believing you might not belong there.

But coding has a funny way of leveling the playing field.

The computer doesn't care who you are.

It doesn't care about your gender, your background, or the expectations people place on you. It only cares about one thing, whether the code works.

And slowly, assignment after assignment, project after project, I realized something important.

My code worked.

By the time I got to my second year, three other women joined the program. I still remember the day I noticed them sitting in the lecture hall. It might seem like a small thing, but it meant more than I expected. Suddenly the room didn't feel quite as lonely.

Their presence reminded me that sometimes the simple act of showing up makes space for someone else to do the same. By the time I graduated, I thought the "only woman in the room" chapter of my life was over.

But when I started my first job as a software engineer, I walked into the office on my first day,

met the engineering team, and realized something familiar.

Once again, I was the only woman on the team. This time, though, the pressure felt different.

In school, you're allowed to learn publicly. In the workplace, you feel like you must prove yourself immediately. Every meeting felt like a small performance. Every technical discussion felt like a moment where I had to show I deserved my seat at the table.

There were days I questioned myself.

Days I worried about speaking up too much, or not enough. Days when I felt the invisible pressure that if I made a mistake, it wouldn't just be my mistake, it would reinforce someone's quiet assumption that women didn't belong in engineering.

But every day, I kept showing up.

I showed up to write code.

I showed up to debug problems.

I showed up to learn, even when learning felt uncomfortable.

And something remarkable happens when you keep showing up long enough. Eventually, people stop seeing you as the only woman in the room. They start seeing you as the engineer who fixed the production bug.

The engineer who built that feature.

The engineer whose ideas improved the product.

Over time, the label fades.

> *"The computer doesn't care who you are. It doesn't care about your gender, your background, or the expectations people place on you. It only cares about one thing, whether the code works."*

Looking back now, I understand that those moments shaped the way I see both myself and my work.

They taught me resilience. They taught me confidence that didn't come from approval, but from persistence. And they taught me something I didn't expect when I first walked into that lecture hall years ago.

Software engineering didn't just become my career. It became a space where I discovered my voice.

Every problem I solved reminded me that I was capable. Every feature I built reminded me that ideas can become real things that people use, rely on, and benefit from. In a world where women are often told where they should or shouldn't belong, technology gave me something powerful, proof that ability speaks louder than expectation.

Today, when I sit in a room discussing architecture, debugging a difficult issue, or watching a product come to life through code, I sometimes remember that first lecture hall.

The rows of faces.

The quiet realization that I was the only girl there. Back then, it felt intimidating. But now I see it differently.

Because technology didn't ask me to fit into a mold that already existed. It gave me the tools to build something new, solutions, systems, and even confidence I didn't know I had. And perhaps that is the quiet power of this field.

It doesn't matter where you started, who expected you to be there, or whether the room was built with you in mind.

If you are willing to learn, to persist, and to keep showing up, technology will make room for you. And sometimes, in the process of building software, you end up building something even more important.

You build yourself.

CHAPTER REFLECTION

The next time you are in a room where someone is the only one, notice it.

Name it if it's safe. Change it if you can. Every room becomes less lonely when someone decides to hold the door open. Who will you hold the door open for?

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Mojisola Alegbe *is a software engineer with over six years of experience building web applications and digital products across healthcare and enterprise platforms. She holds both a bachelor's and a master's degree in Computer Science and currently works on developing scalable systems that support clinical operations and patient management in the United States.*

She is the founder of The Engineer's Network, a community supporting engineers at differentstages of their careers. Mojisola was named among the Most Influential Young Women in Africa (2024), recognized as the #1 JavaScript Creator in Nigeria by Favikon, and nominated for theTop 10 Exceptional Professionals of the Year in Tech at the TIBA Awards 2025.
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CHAPTER THREE

THE BUILDER

Creating What Did Not Exist

When the tools do not exist, build them. When the platforms do not serve your community, create one. When the investors say no, find another way. African women founders are building some of the continent's most innovative startups, often with fewer resources, less visibility, and more obstacles than their male counterparts. Their stories remind us that the future of African technology is not being imported. It is being built from within.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

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Victoria Soluchukwu Ofuasia . Co-founder & AI Researcher . Open Source Nest

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Onuoha Gloria

Founding Social Media Strategist, Digitpay Finance

THE BUILDER

The future is brighter when women stop seeing each other as rivals and start seeing each other as partners" - ***Onuoha Gloria.***

That sentence has stayed with me for a while because it feels very close to my story.

When people talk about technology or fintech products, they often imagine rooms full of men writing code, making decisions, and launching products. For a long time, that was the picture many people had in their minds. But my experience showed me that the picture can be different.

I am one of the women behind DigitPay, and our journey into building it was not just about technology. It was about showing that women can be the faces, the builders, and the drivers of products that solve real problems.

DigitPay started from a simple place: the everyday problems we kept seeing around us. Small business owners struggling with payments, people who want easier ways to send and receive money, and the constant back and forth that comes with making crypto payments. We knew there had to be a better way.

But building something is very different from just talking about it.

In the early days, a lot of things were unclear. There were long conversations, moments where ideas didn't work, and times when we had to figure things out as we went. Building a product is rarely a straight path. Sometimes you think you've solved one problem and three new ones show up.

What made our story special to me was the team behind it. Many of the people helping to build DigitPay were women. Not just supporting from the side, but actually shaping the product, the building, and the direction we were going. We were writing code, designing ideas, creating content, sharing ideas, and bringing the vision to life together.

One thing that stood out during this journey was how much collaboration mattered. There is a popular idea that women have to compete with each other to succeed, especially in spaces like technology. But our experience with DigitPay showed the opposite.

What helped us move forward was community.

Women supporting women. Sharing knowledge. Encouraging each other when something didn't work. Celebrating little progress together. Instead of competing for space, we created space for each other. And that made the journey stronger.

For me, it was powerful to see women standing confidently behind a product like DigitPay. Not waiting to be invited into the room, but creating the room themselves.

And it wasn't always smooth. There are moments when people don't expect women to be the ones building the product. Sometimes the questions come with a little surprise, like, *"Oh, you're part of the team that built this?"* And you can almost hear the unspoken part of the sentence.

But those moments became motivation.

> *"Women are not just users of technology. We are creators of it."*

Every time we showed up to talk about DigitPay, every time we shared the idea, every time someone understood the vision behind it, we were quietly changing the story. We were showing that women are not just users of technology. We are creators of it.

Another thing DigitPay taught me is that building something is rarely a solo journey. It takes people who believe in the vision, people who are willing to try, fail, adjust, and keep going. Our team had many of those moments. The quiet wins, the lessons from things that didn't work, and the excitement when something finally did.

Looking back, I realise that DigitPay became more than just a fintech product to me.

It became proof. Proof that women can build technology that solves real problems. Proof that when women support each other, incredible things can grow from simple ideas. And proof that representation matters. When young girls see women building products, leading conversations, and shaping technology, it expands what they believe is possible for themselves.

I often think about the future of technology in Africa and the stories that will be told years from now. I hope more of those stories include women who decided not to wait for permission.

Women who chose collaboration over competition.

Women who built anyway.

DigitPay is one chapter of that story, and I'm proud to be one of the women helping to write it.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Onuoha Gloria *is the Founding Social Media Strategist at DigitPay Finance and a Google Women Techmakers Ambassador. She is passionate about technology, storytelling, and building communities around ideas that solve real problems. Through her work, she encourages more women to step into tech, believe in themselves, and create solutions that matter.*

She also enjoys being part of communities that support and inspire women in technology.

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Victoria Soluchi Ofuasia

Co-founder and Ai Researcher, Open Source Nest

THE BUILDER

This is my 21st chapter in life. The chapter where I finally accept who I am on the inside. Not who people see me as. Not who I have framed myself as. But who I truly am. I love this chapter because it likens me to a creator. Inventing what does not exist.

I am someone who has gone through several phases of mental stimulation. First, as a young primary school girl, I grew up with a mother who pushed maths into my brain. She is a building engineer - simply put, a builder. My dad would tell me complex accounting details from the age of six. I was exposed to hope from both sides of my parents. And that helped me to see the world beyond limits.

Then the JAMB UTME results came out. I heard someone running out saying someone scored 340 out of 400, and I screamed wondering who that was. Then they said it was me. Me? How? I stood there confused. 'So I can do this?' I said to myself.

My tech journey did not begin in university. It began immediately after secondary school when I started learning web development. I studied Electronic and Computer Engineering at UNN because I wanted to be as close to software engineering as possible.

> *"You are inherently a creator. You were made for this. There is work to do. So do it. You already have everything you need."*

So I did a lot. From coding startups to working with a fintech company, to co-founding an AI community, to leading technical communities, to being trained by GitHub as an open source community manager, to working with Mozilla Common Voice, to co-founding Open Source Nest.

I co-started Open Source Nest because open source was not talked about enough in underserved communities. A lot of people wanted to understand open source but still could not because it remained mystified in tech. Now we are part of the solution to that problem.

Make noise about what you don't like. Be a town crier. But also work on that thing. Gather people. Make a change if no one is making a change. And most importantly, do not be afraid to create your idea out of what you have.

CHAPTER REFLECTION

You do not have to be a startup founder to be a builder.

You can build a team, a community, a curriculum, a movement. What are you building right now? What would you build if you were not afraid? Write it down. Say it out loud. Then take one step toward it.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Victoria Soluchukwu Ofuasia, *a.k.a. Soluchi, is a researcher passionate about reinforcement learning in education and human-centred technology. She focuses on adaptive technologies for education that expand access to knowledge and improve learning experiences. Victoria co-founded Open Source Nest, an initiative introducing underserved communities to open source and technology opportunities.*

Driven by purpose and a desire to create meaningful change, she believes everyone can be carried along in tech when given the right opportunities.

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CHAPTER FOUR

THE TORCHBEARER

Mentorship and Paying It Forward

Mentorship is visibility plus action. It is the phone call that comes at the right moment. The introduction that opens a door. The honest feedback that saves someone from a costly mistake. The women in this chapter are torchbearers. Many of them did not have mentors when they needed them most. So they became the mentors they wished they'd had.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

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Imaabasi Aniema
Virtual Assistant and Cybersecurity Analyst

THE TORCHBEARER

It was an ordinary afternoon at a previous job, when my line manager asked if she could have a word with me. I assumed it was something routine, maybe a quick discussion about an operational issue, so I sat down ready to talk about work. What she said next stopped me completely: she told me she had been watching me, not in the way a supervisor watches an employee, but in quiet admiration, noticing the webinars I attended on my own time, the way I approached problems in the office with a certain technical curiosity, the consistency of someone who kept learning even when nobody had asked her to. Then she said she wanted that for herself and asked me where she should begin.

I remember sitting there genuinely stunned. In my own head, I had simply been doing my small things and minding my business, studying where I could, applying what I learned in tiny practical ways, trying to make sense of my own journey. Yet here was my manager telling me she had been observing from a distance and had found it inspiring enough to say so out loud. When she eventually completed one of the courses I recommended and came back to me with thank-yous so warm they almost embarrassed me, I could see the difference in her immediately. Something had opened for her, some door she had not realised was available, and somehow I had been the one to push it open without even knowing I was doing it.

I tell that story first because it was the moment that forced me to look back and recognise something I had been building quietly without any blueprint, what had been happening around me while I was busy doubting myself.

You see, my entry into tech was not dramatic or particularly deliberate. All I had were free opportunities I spent time hunting for, sometimes patiently, sometimes desperately, because those were the only doors available to me at the time and I walked through every single one I could find. If there was a free programme, a free webinar, a free bootcamp or a free training slot somewhere on the internet, I was there, collecting whatever knowledge I could and trying to make it mean something.

In those early days I was not even sure what I wanted to do. I remember vividly how the rave in my immediate circle then was software engineering and coding, and since everyone seemed to be doing it successfully, I convinced myself I could do it too. I joined what was essentially a free virtual programme with every intention of becoming the next person writing code and building things. I lasted exactly two days. Two days that came with a headache so intense it almost felt personal, like my brain had decided to protest loudly against the entire arrangement. By the end of the second day I was exhausted, confused, and very aware that something about that path simply was not working for me. I did not return. To this day I still carry a quiet guilt about that wasted slot because it could easily have gone to someone who was fully ready for it and I clearly was not.

What found me next was cybersecurity, and it began with something surprisingly simple. I just liked the sound of it. I liked the

idea of securing systems, protecting information, and it appealed to me in a way coding never quite did. Now, that does not mean learning cybersecurity was easy. There were moments during the process when I struggled with concepts, wrestled with technical details, and occasionally wondered if I had once again walked into something that might defeat me. But this time the structure made sense, the foundations were clearer, and I could slowly build understanding layer by layer until I finally came out the other side with something real inside me.

Then life, as it often does, redirected me again. Today I work as a Virtual Assistant supporting C-suite executives, and I know how that might sound after everything I have just described, but the truth is my cybersecurity background has never left the work I do. It shows up in the way I handle sensitive information, in how I think about digital workflows, in the instincts I bring to operational processes that others might treat casually.

> *"Mentorship, sometimes, is not a path we deliberately hop on. Sometimes it is simply a woman who is still becoming, turning around to reach back because she remembers clearly what it felt like to be searching for a door that nobody seemed willing to open."*

Now this is a bit of my tech story and honestly, what I did not anticipate along this path I chose was the women who would begin to show up. They started appearing through referrals, through casual conversations, through messages that usually began with the same sentence. “Ima, I want to go into tech, but I’m scared.” Some did not know where to begin, others had already started but felt completely overwhelmed by the question of specialization. Should they go into product design, cybersecurity, virtual assistance, or something else entirely?

I answered every single one of them in my own little way. Sometimes it was a long conversation, sometimes it was simply sharing resources or pointing someone in the direction of a course or community that helped me once. But I always gave freely because every free opportunity someone created somewhere is the reason I am here today. Gatekeeping knowledge in tech is a choice, and it is a choice I refused, and still refuse to make.

Every success my women eventually experienced became something I carried quietly as well. Their wins felt like small feathers in my own cap because they saw what was possible in my journey and realised it could be possible for them too.

Mentorship, sometimes, is not a path we deliberately hop on. Sometimes it is simply a woman who is still becoming, turning around to reach back because she remembers clearly what it felt like to be searching for a door that nobody seemed willing to open and it was only recently I recognised that truly, I had been a mentor to my women.

In the near future, I hope to pay forward, in a much larger way, the blessing of free access that gave me my own beginning. I know what it means to be the woman hunting for opportunity and searching for the next small opening and if I can be someone’s door, that is more than enough.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Imaabasi Aniema Offiongudo *is a Virtual Assistant and Cybersecurity Analyst based in Abuja, Nigeria, who supports senior executives while bringing a strong technical understanding of digital systems and security into her work. Her journey into tech was unconventional and shaped through continuous learning, certifications, and hands-on problem solving rather than a straight path. Beyond her professional work, Ima has become an informal but deeply intentional mentor to women navigating their own paths into technology, guiding them through the fog of uncertainty she once knew intimately. She believes that imperfection is not a barrier to impact, and that a woman who is still figuring it out can still be the light another woman needs.*

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Anyika Uchechukwu Lorretta

Data Analyst, Federated Engineers

THE TORCHBEARER

Among the different themes I could have written about, I chose mentorship because it sits at the heart of my journey.

As I write this, I remember the very first student I ever taught data analysis. It was 2024. I had just completed the Google Data Analytics Certificate and had returned from my SIWES programme at Caritas Nigeria, Enugu Office. I was in my third year at the university, still very much a student myself.

If you know me, you will know that I am quite petite, but that has always been one of my greatest prides. I enjoy surprising people with what I can do. As I like to joke, I enjoy building big things from small places.

My first student was the complete opposite of me. He was physically bigger, older, and a guy. If I remember correctly, he should be a 400-level student but in a different department. Ordinarily, I should have felt intimidated. What made me think I could sit this guy down and teach him something? What made me think he would listen to me and actually act on what I was teaching?

Looking back now, I surprise myself.

At the time, I had no formal classroom and no structure. Sometimes we held lessons at Al-tinez, that Pharmacy 300-level class, also used as the auditorium in the Pharmacy building.. I would carry a large Acer laptop that looked almost too big for my small frame.

But it was what I had, and I made use of it. My student, on the other hand, used a sleek Dell laptop. The irony always made me smile.

We had three sessions every week, and each session lasted about three hours. I would arrive early to secure a quiet corner for both of us. My extension and adapter were always in my bag. Survival skills. If there was no electricity nearby, I needed to be ready to find a socket somewhere. You can imagine the mental preparation every time: planning for light, planning for space.

For both electricity and quiet, that location was perfect. But I always taught in hushed tones so as not to disturb other students who were reading. On Sundays, when the class spaces were locked, we sometimes met in my office because I was serving as the Vice President of the Nigerian Association of Physical Sciences Students. That was the set up.

Our first topic was Excel.

The idea was simple: teach one person the things I had just learned from the Google Data Analytics programme. I have always believed that if you can teach something, then you truly understand it.

So we would sit there for hours. I prepared slides using pitch.com. I researched Excel deeply, moving from the basics to advanced practices. I practiced until I could explain formulas, data cleaning, and simple analysis in ways that someone completely new could understand.

At that point, my YouTube history was filled with data analytics tutorials and even videos on how to teach.

Before this, I had taught students different subjects - Mathematics, English, Physics, Statistics, Igbo. Teaching has always been part of me. The only difference now was that

this was the data space, and I was still early in my journey. But, I decided to wing it. Take a chance and teach; at least the ones I knew then.

The first day we met, I asked him a simple question.

"*Why do you want to learn data analysis?"*

Clearly not a technical question. Not about Excel. Not about formulas. Just a simple question to understand his reason. I remember him pausing for a moment. Not the kind of pause where someone is thinking of a clever answer. It was the kind of pause that felt honest. Like he had never really been asked that question before.

Then he said:

"I want to understand data, but I do not know where to start."

That response stayed with me. Not because it was profound. But because it was real. There was no big ambition in that sentence. No fancy career goals. Just confusion... and curiosity.

I realized that so many people are standing at the edge of something they want to learn, but they feel locked out. Not because they are not capable. Not because they are not intelligent. But because they do not know where the starting point is. They are waiting for

clarity. Waiting for direction. Waiting for someone to show them that first step.

That day, I understood that mentorship is not always about teaching advanced concepts. Sometimes, it is simply about removing that first layer of confusion.

Sometimes, it is about sitting beside someone and saying:

"You are not behind. You are just at the beginning."

That moment became my *"why."*

Because every time I teach, I am not just explaining data.I am helping someone cross that invisible line between "I do not know how to start" and "I think I can do this."

So when people ask me today,

"Lorreta, why do you even bother?"

I do not need to think too hard. I smile. Because I remember that moment.

And I remember that sometimes, all it takes to change someone's direction is one conversation, one question, and one person willing to say: let us start together.

> *"Mentorship is not a stage you arrive at. It is a decision you make. Sometimes, it begins before you feel ready."*

The Ripple Effect

What started as one student slowly became something more. Word began to spread. More students became interested. Questions turned into conversations, and conversations turned into teaching sessions.

At some point, I had the idea to record our sessions and share them publicly. I would post mostly on my WhatsApp status. Then on LinkedIn and Facebook too. At first, it felt like nothing was happening. But people were watching quietly.

Soon, we began holding sessions at the AEDJAC Lab. It was a more conducive environment, and I could feel the momentum building. Before long, I started receiving invitations to teach smaller groups of students.

On my own end, the ripple effect was shocking. Now, the good thing was that, as I taught,

I learned more. You know how these things work? You have to be prepared. Students

would ask questions like: "If there is an outlier in a dataset, which measure should you use - mean or median?" Or"*What chart*

is best for this type of data? Knowing that questions like these must arise forced me to dig deeper. I would not want to look foolish right? That was it then. Being a step ahead every time.

What began with one person in a quiet corner of a campus building had grown into something bigger.

I started getting speaking engagements. My leadership role as NAPSS VP amplified my reach. I began working more with data, learning statistical research, and eventually getting paid opportunities.

But for a long time, it was all volunteer work. My time, resources, every thing

After school, I expanded my mentorship beyond physical spaces. I launched my own initiative and continued teaching undergraduates data analytics. I kept showing up.

In all of these, I feel the most beautiful thing is the ease I had finding mentors for my journey ahead too. The same way I had shown up for others, people began to show up for me.

This year's International Women's Day theme is ***Give to Gain.***

Today, I am living that truth.

I have never needed to learn a skill and struggled to find guidance for long. Somehow, the right people appear. Mentors who invest in me. People who open doors.

Today, I have my full time job and currently under the mentorship of Mayowa Akinyele, learning data engineering and working alongside teams building real systems. I see it as a privilege to be amongst the team. Just when I decided to transition to data engineering, I got myself the best mentor and team.

And I often ask myself:

Did these opportunities come because I was the most qualified? Or because I showed up, shared what I knew, and made myself visible?

Looking back, I understand something clearly now.

Mentorship is not a stage you arrive at.

It is a decision you make. Sometimes, it begins before you feel ready. Sometimes, it begins with one student, one laptop, a quiet corner and the courage to give, even when you are still becoming.

Because in the end, the fastest way to claim your seat at the table is to start pulling up chairs for others.

CHAPTER REFLECTION

Think of one woman who is two steps behind where you are right now.

How could you reach back? Not to carry her but to show her the path. A message, a referral, a coffee chat, an honest conversation. Mentorship does not have to be formal to be transformational.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Lorreta Anyika *builds scalable data systems and has led data analytics bootcamps, equipping students with practical, job-ready skills.*

Her work sits at the intersection of data engineering, statistics, and health research, with a particular focus on HIV care, anomaly detection for early risk identification, and epidemiological analysis. Through her research and writing, she explores how data-driven systems can strengthen health outcomes and improve decision-making in resource-constrained environments.

Passionate about democratizing access to data knowledge, Lorreta actively contributes to both data engineering and health communities, particularly in communications and knowledge-sharing roles.

Her favourite mantra, "Another day to be 1% better," reflects her belief that consistent, incremental improvement can compound into extraordinary impact over time.

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CHAPTER FIVE

THE RESISTANCE

Overcoming Bias and Discrimination

Bias in tech wears many faces. It is the recruiter who assumes the male candidate is more technically capable. It is the performance review that describes a woman as 'aggressive' for behaviour applauded in her male colleague. The women in this chapter have been extraordinary in their resistance - strategic, persistent, and clear-eyed. They have not always won every battle. But they have refused to be reduced by the battles they have faced.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

Adaugo Okwara Munachiso . Product Designer . Independent

Oluwatoyin Mary Oladeji . Tech-Programme Coach . Multiverse . United Kingdom

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Adaugo Okwara
Product Designer

THE RESISTANCE

I'll just talk about my journey. It hasn't been easy in the tech space. From volunteering, to working for startups, to being underpaid, it's really been a journey.

It all started after I graduated from secondary school. I was just at home, and at that time I actually had plans to learn fashion designing. But along the line, I came across a tech program - six months of frontend and backend development. Funny enough, I was already two weeks late when the program started. I didn't even have a laptop. And most of the people in the program were guys. We were only two girls among more than twenty guys. But I didn't let that discourage me. I took money from my savings and bought a laptop for 50k instead of accepting a free one.

Along the way, I started noticing something about myself, I was more interested in design. I would stay up all night learning new things about design. Anytime we were put into groups, I would quickly nominate myself to handle the design and the case study.

After months of learning, I was among the best students selected for a paid internship at top companies in Lagos. But I had already gotten admission into school. So I chose school. After settling down in school, I got an offer from a foreign company. The salary was $100 per month. I was so excited. But I didn't know I was being deceived. I worked for them and designed for the company. The first month passed and they didn't pay me. It was a scam. They eventually ghosted me.

> *"All the bias, the exploitation, the underpayment, and the setbacks didn't stop my journey. They only made me stronger."*

Then came the hackathon that broke something in me. Our team won a Web3 hackathon with prize money of over 50 million naira. Unknown to me, these guys had already shared the prize money and upgraded their gadgets. When I finally asked about my share, they told me the money was only for the developers. That design was not included.

But something important was happening during all those struggles. I was growing. Not just my skills, but my mindset. And not just my mindset, but my sense of value.

Early last year, I finally told the CEO I was resigning. And when I left, I took the deepest breath of relief.

After I resigned, I started getting gigs, some from Nigerian clients and some from foreign clients. And the pay was actually really good. In fact, I landed one of the biggest gigs of my career. That single gig alone paid me more than that company paid me for an entire year.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Munachi Okwara *is a creative product designer with several years of experience working on projects related to AI, Web3, and other digital platforms. She has contributed her design skills to communities such as BlockchainUNN, AlphaBlocksTech, and WTM, where she focuses on creating thoughtful and user-friendly designs.*

Known for her attention to detail and creativity, she consistently delivers quality work. Beyond product design, Adaugo is also skilled in brand design, illustration, and motion design. She enjoys mentoring upcoming designers and helping them find their path in the design space. In her free time, she enjoys creating and editing videos for fun.

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Oluwatoyin Mary Oladeji

Tech-Programme Coach, Multiverse

THE RESISTANCE

My story is unconventional. It is rarely told. It might read differently from the other stories in this book, but what it is not, is uncommon. Thousands of women feel exactly this way. Maybe men too **laughs**.

As someone who had the privilege of studying Computer Science, the world seemed pretty clear on what I should become. A software developer. Learn to code. And if not that, maybe a

Product Manager? build products alongside engineers, sit close enough to the technical work to count. These were the expected paths. The respectable ones.

But they never felt right for me.

I knew the sector well enough to know what was expected, what to learn, which courses to take, which internships to chase. And I tried. Each time I followed that pathway, what came back was a kind of emptiness I could not explain. I was doing the right things. I was performing well academically. And yet something was consistently, quietly wrong.

I carried that tension all the way through university. It was not until my National Youth Service Corps year, volunteering to teach young children at an IDP camp in Abuja, that something finally clicked.

I am not even sure I recognised it in the moment. I just knew that I enjoyed it, genuinely, fully enjoyed it. Teaching the basics of computing to kids who had never touched a keyboard.

Working alongside other volunteers. Planning the setup of an IT lab we were providing for them. There was no emptiness in any of it. Just presence, and purpose, and the feeling that this was exactly where I was supposed to be.

Not in the code. In the program around it.

A few months after youth service, I got an internship with Tech4Dev to design and implement digital skilling programs for women across Africa. Here, I got to work with instructors, volunteers, other program managers, but most importantly, with women who wanted to enter the industry and did not know how. My knowledge of the tech sector helped me understand their frustrations when things got difficult. My passion for program design helped me build initiatives that were genuinely impactful. For the first time, both sides of me were being used at once. It felt like relief.

But I wanted more context. I knew Africa was my starting point, but I needed to understand the wider development landscape, how decisions about access and empowerment were being made at a global level, and where we fit into that picture.

> *"You do not just need people who build the technology. You need people who build the road to it."*

I applied for scholarships. I was accepted to study Africa and International Development at the University of Edinburgh under the Mastercard Foundation Scholarship.

Every time I had to explain that choice, the questions came. Why not an MSc in Computer Science? Why not become a developer? It is more profitable! Each time, my answer was the same: because I want to change the world through initiatives, policies, programmes, and contextual knowledge. That path has more longevity. It is how we produce more coders and developers particularly those who would never have had access otherwise. You do not just need people who build the technology. You need people who build the road to it.

It was not a conventional answer. It did not look ideal to most people. But it was mine.

Today I work with Multiverse, one of the UK's leading edtech companies, supporting people within the workforce whose roles are being reshaped by an ever-evolving world of technology. I help ensure they get the right skills to remain effective, confident, and valuable providing job security for individuals and real return on investment for businesses through data and AI skilling.

And where do I want to go from here? I want to be in the rooms where decisions are made. I have worked across developing and developed countries, with women and men, with the employed and the unemployed. I have seen programmes designed for different people in different contexts, and I have watched what works and what doesn't. What I know is this: technology is already changing how we live. And AI is not coming, it is here exponentially driving this change. What matters now is who gets prepared for it, and who gets left behind.

I want to be one of the people who makes sure the answer to that question is more just than it currently is.

So no, this is not a conventional path. But here is what I need you to hear, especially if you are somewhere I once was - capable, curious, and quietly convinced that the role everyone expects of you is not the one you were made for.

Do not confuse other people's clarity about your future for your own. They can see what you studied. They cannot see what moves you.

Purpose and fulfillment are not soft things. They are the reason some people sustain careers that last decades while others burn out chasing titles they were told to want. When you find the space where your knowledge and your passion meet, protect it. Build in it. Do not shrink it to fit someone else's definition of success.

The tech industry is not a single road. It is an entire landscape and there is a place in it for you that does not require you to be anyone other than who you already are.

Find it. Own it.

CHAPTER REFLECTION

You cannot break a pattern you cannot name.

Think about a moment when bias - yours or someone else's showed up in a professional or educational setting. What was the pattern? How was it reinforced? And crucially, what would it take to break it? Awareness is the beginning of change.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Oluwatoyin Mary Oladeji *is a Tech-Programme Coach at Multiverse, one of the UK's leading edtech companies, where she supports individuals and businesses in building the skills needed to thrive in an AI-driven world. With a background in Computer Science and a postgraduate degree in Africa and International Development from the University of Edinburgh, supported by the Mastercard Foundation Scholarship, she has spent her career at the intersection of technology and human skills and access. She previously designed and implemented digital skilling programmes reaching thousands of women across Africa at Tech4Dev and worked at the University of Edinburgh as a curriculum transformation intern.*

Oluwatoyin believes that the most important work in tech is not always building new technology but empowering humans to effectively make the best use of it.

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CHAPTER SIX

THE EXECUTIVE

Rising to Leadership on Her Own Terms

Leadership in technology has historically been written in a particular language - the language of the young, male, and conventionally educated. The women in this chapter have risen to the top as CEOs, CTOs, VPs, Directors, and Department Heads. But they did not rise by becoming versions of what was already there. They rose by redefining what leadership looks like: with empathy, with community, with a commitment to bringing others along.

CONTRIBUTORS IN THIS CHAPTER

Helen Okereke . Software and Robotics Engineer
Patricia Oko. Product Designer and manager

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Helen Okereke
Software and Robotics Engineer

THE EXECUTIVE

I come from a small village called Uburu in Ebonyi State, Nigeria, where opportunities are not always visible and most people grow into what is available around them. But even as a child, I had a different kind of dream. I wanted to become what I called a "computer wizard." I didn't even know if that was a real thing, but in my mind, it meant someone who could use computers to do what felt like magic to create things, to solve problems, to make life easier for people. That was what I wanted.

My mum always wanted me to become a medical doctor. Like many African parents, she believed it was the safest and most respected path, and she supported me wholeheartedly in that direction because she truly wanted the best for me. But of course, I had a different dream worth fighting for. I remember telling her that it wouldn't work, that what I wanted was different.

I wanted to study computer engineering and build with technology. Even though I could not fully explain it at the time, I believed strongly that I could do more with tech and that it was where I truly belonged. After secondary school, I began my journey at Aptech Computer Education in Enugu, where I studied Software Engineering for two years. That was my first real encounter with technology. Before then, I didn't even own a phone, so everything felt completely new to me. I was learning from scratch, trying to understand how things worked, and slowly finding my place in it. During that time, I was introduced to the Internet of Things, and something about it immediately felt different.

For the first time, technology became more than just code on my computer screen. It became something I could use to build real, physical systems, things people could see, touch, and interact with. In that moment, I realized I had found something that connected deeply with the dream I had carried for so long. It felt like I was finally becoming the "computer wizard" I had always imagined. From that moment, I knew I didn't just want to learn alone, so I started building. I worked on both software and IoT projects, spending long hours trying things out, getting stuck, buying learning materials, sometimes damaging them because of bad connections, and still trying again. It wasn't always smooth, but I enjoyed it.

I was learning in a way that felt real, and for the first time, I could actually see myself growing into what I had imagined. Not long after, I got my first job as a web developer in Nigeria. It was a big moment for me. It meant that everything I had been learning was starting to make sense. I was gaining experience, getting better, and slowly finding my place in tech. But even as I was growing, I kept thinking about other people who were where I used to be, people who were curious but didn't know where to start.

So I decided to start tech public speaking. I began volunteering, speaking at events, and organizing workshops for students and beginners. Most of the time, I sponsored myself. I travelled across different states in Nigeria, sometimes without knowing how everything would work out, but I went anyway because I believed it mattered. I just wanted to make an impact in the lives of people. Even during the times when I felt like I was still trying to figure things out for myself, I kept teaching and sharing. Somehow, those moments became some of the most meaningful parts of my journey.

Whenever someone told me that a workshop helped them understand something new or gave them the confidence to start their journey in tech, it always meant a lot to me. It reminded me that what I was doing was not just about me anymore, but also about opening doors for others.

As I continued on that path, people started noticing the work I was doing. I was featured on Google Maps as a Women Techmakers builder in Africa, and that moment meant a lot because it showed me that the impact I was making was reaching beyond Nigeria. I also became a Google Women Techmakers Ambassador, and together with Patricia, I established the Women Techmakers Nsukka community. We created a space where women could learn, grow, and feel like they belonged in tech. And while all of this was happening, I was still building myself too, learning, growing, trying to become better.

In 2024, I made the decision to move to Rwanda to study Software Engineering at the African Leadership University. It was a big step for me, leaving everything familiar and stepping into a completely new environment, but of course, I had God by my side. I wasn't just going there to study. I was going there to grow, to stretch myself, and to build something more meaningful. That desire to solve real problems had always been part of me, and being in a new country made me more aware of the world around me. I paid attention to how things worked, the challenges people faced, and where technology could make a difference. As I settled into life in Rwanda, I began to notice something disturbing.

There were a lot of road accidents, and many of them led to serious injuries or even loss of life, not just because of the crash itself, but because emergency response often came late. In most cases, everything depended on passersby noticing and making calls for help, and the more I thought about it, the more it bothered me because this wasn't just a Rwanda problem.

It reflected what was happening across Africa where there was no automatic system and people simply depended on chance, hoping someone would be there to call for help in time, and I couldn't ignore that reality, so I kept asking myself one question over and over again, what if vehicles could actually call for help? That was how L-Guard started. **L-Guard** is an IoT-powered road safety system that detects accidents in real time and instantly sends alerts to nearby hospitals and emergency responders, providing the exact location and severity of the accident. With a system like this, emergency responders don't have to wait for someone to call for help, they can act immediately, and more lives can be saved.

Building it has been one of the most challenging things I have done. There were moments when things didn't work, when we had to go back, rethink, and try again. But this time, the stakes felt different. This wasn't just about building a project. It was about saving lives. And that kept me going.

Today, L-Guard has grown beyond just an idea. We have raised over $33,500 in non-dilutive funding, developed working prototypes, and deployed pilot devices that are already collecting real data on the roads. We are working with partners and continuing to improve the system, one step at a time.

When I look at this journey, it still feels surreal sometimes. I went from a girl in a small village who simply wanted to become a "computer wizard," to someone now building solutions that can impact lives across Africa. It reminds me that where you start does not define where you can go. Even when the path is not clear, you can still move forward, still grow, still build something meaningful. If there is anything I would want someone reading this to take away, it is this: There is more for you than what is in front of you right now.

Your background does not limit your future. Don't be afraid to hope and dream. Dream very big, no matter how big your dream is, you have the power to unlock it.

It might not make sense right now, but start now, keep building, growing and you will definitely become that dream you once had.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Helen Okereke *is the CEO of L-Guard, where she is building technology that aims to improve emergency response and save lives.*

She is a software and robotics engineer, with a strong passion for using technology to solve real-world problems.

Helen is also dedicated to mentoring young people, especially women and kids, helping them gain tech skills and build confidence in the field.
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CHAPTER REFLECTION

Leadership is not a destination, it is a practice.

How are you leading right now, regardless of your title? In your team, your community, your household, your circle? What kind of leader do you want to become? Who can you ask to hold you accountable to that vision?

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Patricia Oko

Product designer and Manager

THE EXECUTIVE

What do you do when everything you planned for yourself quietly closes its doors and leaves you standing in a hallway you did not choose, holding a key that fits nothing?

Do you go back? Do you wait? Or do you look around and ask yourself whether maybe, just maybe, this hallway was always where you were meant to be?

I have asked myself that question more times than I can count. And the answer, every single time, has led me deeper into the life I now get to call mine.

But I am getting ahead of myself. Let me take you back to the beginning or at least, to what I thought was the beginning.

For most of my life, I was going to be a doctor. That was not just a career choice, it was a certainty I carried in my chest the way some people carry faith. I wanted to heal people. I wanted the white coat, the weight of responsibility, the particular satisfaction of doing something that genuinely mattered.

Computer science, when it showed up in my secondary school timetable, was never part of that dream. It was that subject - the one I struggled through, the one that made me work twice as hard for half the reward. I passed it. But I did not love it. And I certainly did not imagine it would one day become the soil everything else grew from.

When I got to university and found out I had not been admitted into medicine, that I would be studying Biotechnology instead, something in me went very quiet. I did not talk about it much. I adjusted, the way young people learn to adjust when the world does not move in the direction they pointed at. But I grieved it privately, the white coat, the dream. The version of myself I had been rehearsing.

I had no idea that grief was making space.

> *"I grieved the plan I had rehearsed my whole life. I did not know that grief was making space for something I could not yet name."*

Then came the ASUU strike.

If you have ever been a student in Nigeria, you know the particular purgatory of a strike, the weeks that stretch into months, the loss of rhythm, the unsettling feeling of time passing without moving. I needed something to hold onto. A secondary school friend of mine, someone who was studying Computer Science, started talking to me about coding. She was patient, generous, genuinely excited to share what she knew.

There was just one problem.

I did not have a laptop.

Three words that sound so simple and mean so much. Without a laptop, I could not run environments, could not practise, could not do most of what she was trying to teach me. So we just couldn't move forward.

At the same time, I discovered something I could do with what I already had in my hand. I started learning graphic design on Canva with my phone. And something unexpected happened. I fell in love. Not just

with the work, but with what the work was telling me about myself.

I found an old journal entry written years before, when I was young enough to write things down without second-guessing them. In it, I had said I wanted to become a graphic designer. I had completely forgotten. The journal had not.

That quiet rediscovery felt like a hand on my shoulder. Like something saying: you have been walking in the right direction longer than you knew.

A reading community I found on Instagram gave me my first real opportunity - a graphic design internship with a small stipend. They even invested in a course to upgrade my skills. I was grateful in the way you are when someone hands you something you did not dare ask for.

But the course required a laptop.

Still, I did not have one. Months passed and my output was not improving fast enough, not for lack of trying, but for lack of access. The tools I needed existed just slightly beyond what I could reach. Eventually, they let me go.

I remember reading that email. I remember the particular silence that followed, the kind that is not peaceful, but heavy. I had tried. I had shown up. And it had not been enough, not because of who I was, but because of what I did not have.

That day, I decided to become intentional with my savings, it became my priority. Every penny I made from my little hustle (writing, filling CAs, assignments) in school went into my savings. I took everything I had, and bought a laptop.

I cried that day, genuinely. And then I opened the laptop.

The laptop changed everything. Not because it was magic, but because it removed the one thing that had been standing between me and everything I was trying to do. Suddenly I could apply for scholarships. I found free bootcamps and online courses and stayed up late consuming them. I was still a full-time student, still physically attending lectures, still managing coursework and exams, but now I was also managing a hunger that had been waiting a long time to be fed properly.

I applied for a cybersecurity scholarship. It fascinated me, the idea of protecting systems, of understanding vulnerabilities, of working in a space that required both logic and intuition. Unfortunately, I did not get in.

What came instead was a scholarship in Product Design. I had never heard those two words together. I was not sure what it meant, whether it was for me, whether I should accept something I had not gone looking for.

But I had been learning, slowly and painfully, that the opportunities you did not knock on can be the ones that change everything. So I said yes.

And product design, I say this plainly, became the best decision of my professional life.

The scholarship was a one-year intensive programme. I was still in university. Both demanded my full presence. Neither was negotiable.

I had to wear airpods in lectures to attend online design classes at the same time. I became an expert in the particular art of being physically somewhere while mentally somewhere else, in the most productive sense of the phrase. I gave myself one unbreakable rule: I would not carry any task from one week into the next. No matter how buried I felt by Friday, I would resurface by Sunday. Every week would start clean.

There were days I cried in those online classes. Days the volume of everything; exams, assignments, deadlines stacking up on top of each other, felt less like ambition and more like punishment. In my final year, I had to reschedule a module test because my university exam fell on the same day and I simply could not split myself in two.

But I showed up. Every time, I showed up.

I graduated from that programme with a Cumma Sum Laude. The girl who couldn't practice coding, who cried over a rejection

email, who spent her last naira on a laptop, she had built something real.

While I was learning, I had been sharing my journey online throughout, not to perform expertise I did not have, but because sharing was how I proved to myself that I was actually moving. I didn't know someone was watching. A company reached out, offered me an internship, and three months later retained me to lead their product team. Real products, real users, real stakes. Things I could not have fully learned in any classroom.

That experience, and the startups I worked with afterwards, taught me the difference between knowing something and being able to do something with it under pressure. I learned to lead teams, to navigate ambiguity, to sit with users and understand problems that are never quite as simple as the brief suggests.

Today, I work at the intersection of people and products - as a product designer and a technical product manager. And every single day, I feel the quiet wonder of someone doing exactly what they were made to do, even though nobody, including me, could have drawn a straight line from where I started to where I am now.

But here is the truth underneath all of it. The truth I did not fully understand until I lived it. None of this happened alone.

When I was at my most stretched, balancing two worlds, exhausted, doubting whether any of it was worth it, it was the women around me who kept me going. A community I found through Tech4Dev became my anchor. Women who checked in on the days I could not show up. Women who understood the weight of what I was carrying because they were carrying versions of it too. Women who reminded me, in the small consistent ways that matter most, that I was not doing this alone.

That experience changed me more than any certificate ever could.

It made me want to build. In 2003, together with my dear friend Helen Okereke, I began building a community, starting at my alma mater and growing outward from there. We built it because we had felt what it was like to need it and not find it immediately. We built it so that the women coming after us would have something we had to search for.

Building that community did something I did not expect. It did not just help others. It helped me. Every resource I found, every opportunity I surfaced, every mentor I connected someone with, all fed back into my own growth in ways that were invisible at first but undeniable over time. I was not just building for my community. I was building what I needed.

Why This Book Exists

This is why I curated From the Margins to the Mainstream.

Not because I have arrived somewhere perfect. Not because my story is the most dramatic or the most inspiring in these pages, it is not. But because I have lived enough of this journey to know that the most dangerous thing we can do is let it stay private.

When I couldn't practice coding because I had no laptop, I thought that was the end. When I cried over an email and spent my last savings on a device, I thought I was just recovering. When I wore earphones in lectures and stayed up until midnight completing coursework that two different worlds were demanding of me, I thought I was just managing.

But looking back, I was breaking patterns. The pattern of waiting for the right tools. The pattern of choosing one thing because the world said you could not hold two. The pattern of keeping your journey quiet because it is messy and uncertain and nobody writes about the part before the breakthrough.

The women in this book broke patterns too. all of them, in six different ways, all arriving at the same truth, that the margins were never where they belonged.

And neither were you. Whatever hallway you are standing in right now, whatever door has just closed, whatever plan has just unraveled, I want you to know what I know

now: this is not the end of the story. This is the part where it actually begins.

ABOUT THE CONTRIBUTOR

Patricia Oko *is a creative product designer Product manager creating meaningful identities, systems and experiences. With a passion for creating user-centered experiences through her creative and research skills.*
A program manager for Code and Create Bootcamp, a fully virtual free training program designed to equip young Nigerians from low income and marginalized communities with beginner to intermediate skills to start their careers, access decent jobs and entrepreneurship, as a pathway to economic livelihood.
As a young girl building a global career in tech and non-profit leadership, she passionately advocates for women in tech and believes that education and technology can be used to empower young people. Her strategies are embedded in the power of education, community, and technology to change lives.
Her mantra is "True impact is not always loud, but through consistent and people-centered activities, a lot of positive changes can be made, and these can start from where one is in one's little capacity".
Beyond technical pursuits, she loves volunteering, reading, travelling, and exploring the world of art.

LinkedIn: Patricia Oko

COMMUNITY VOICES

PATTERNS WE HAVE BROKEN

Women Techmakers Nsukka

The stories in this book belong to remarkable women. But breaking the pattern is never the work of a few, it is the daily, quiet, courageous act of an entire community.

As part of the International Women's Day 2026 celebration in Nsukka, the women nominated for our Women's Spotlight were invited to share one thing: the pattern they had to break to move forward in their tech journey. What came back was extraordinary, responses about boundaries and burnout, about learning with a six-inch screen, about crying in a CorelDRAW class and designing a graduation calendar anyway. About waiting to feel ready and deciding, finally, not to wait. About being told that being a woman meant doing more for less and choosing differently.

These are not footnotes to this book. They are its heartbeat.

Each voice below represents hundreds of women who have lived a version of the same story but have not yet had a space to say it out loud. We offer these words as proof that the pattern is being broken - one woman, one decision, one brave story at a time.

Amarachukwu Awaeze

"I broke the pattern of overextending myself by learning to define and protect my professional boundaries. When a client assumed that being a woman meant I would multitask beyond my agreed scope without complaint, I calmly redirected us to our original terms. I learned that my time, energy, and vision are not negotiable and that saying no is not a setback, it is a strategy.

"I broke the pattern of mistaking movement for growth. For a long time I said yes to almost everything, until burnout forced me to be honest with myself about direction. I learned that growth is not about doing the most, it is about doing what is most aligned. That shift from intense urgency to intentional, grounded progress has shaped everything about how I show up in tech today.

Soluchi

Agbo Ruth

"I broke the pattern of consuming information without taking action. I used to jump between opportunities like SEO, trading, digital marketing, often mistaking exploration for progress. The real shift came when I chose one path, committed to consistent

Tabitha Ngozi

"I broke the pattern of waiting for permission to belong in the digital world. Without a tech background, I chose to learn before I felt ready, following mentors, reading voraciously, and building in spite of self-doubt and the quiet whisper that this space was not for women like me. Goal Quest Academy was born from that refusal, and has since trained over 700 entrepreneurs and students.

"I broke the pattern of waiting until I was perfect before I started. I used to believe I needed to understand everything before writing a single line of code or joining a single opportunity. When I stopped waiting for permission and started building in public, even without a laptop at times, I stopped seeing tech as a space I had to earn, and started seeing it as a space I already belonged in.

Ezinne Boluwatife

Igwe Favour

"I broke the pattern of learning in silence and waiting to feel ready before showing up. I used to believe that visibility was something earned only at the finish line of perfection. Breaking that pattern meant sharing my work before it was polished, speaking up before I felt certain, and unlearning the belief that a woman must shrink herself before she is allowed to take up space.

"

I broke the pattern of being a silent observer. My tech journey began with tears in a CorelDRAW class during COVID - a girl who could not turn on a computer, terrified of being left behind. But I kept showing up, and the same girl who cried over that first lesson went on to design the graduation calendar her entire school talked about. Today, as I pursue a career in Artificial Intelligence, I am driven by one truth: women are not just welcome in these spaces, we are essential to them.

Maryann Ifeoma

Emezionye Chinemerme

"

I broke the pattern of inconsistency. Women in tech are given opportunities such as free trainings, workshops, conferences, mentorship - but what we do after receiving those opportunities is what truly defines our journey. I chose to keep practising, keep learning, and keep sharing, because real change comes not from access alone but from what we build with it.

"

I broke the pattern of believing that tools define potential. In a room full of laptops and high-end processors, I showed up with a smartphone, a book, and a refusal to be outpaced by what I lacked. That constraint forced me to develop my most powerful asset: my voice. Today I advocate for human-centered technology because I am living proof that you do not need a full setup to start a revolution, you just need the audacity to stay in the room.

Onyinye Rosemary

AFTERWORD

THE PATTERN HAS BEEN BROKEN

By Patricia Oko

When we began this project, we asked women a simple question: 'What pattern did you have to break to get where you are today?' The answers we received were not simple. They were layered, complex, honest, and sometimes painful. They were also, without exception, inspiring.

What we found is this: the patterns that limit women in tech are not natural. They are constructed, built slowly over time by assumptions, structures, and silences. And what is constructed can be deconstructed. What has been built can be rebuilt differently.

The women in this book did not wait for the world to change before they moved. They moved, and the world shifted a little in response. That is how change works, not in one dramatic moment, but in thousands of small, intentional acts of resistance and creation.

We hope this book is a resource, a mirror, and a spark. We hope it makes you feel less alone in your journey. And we hope it reminds you that from the margins, you have always had what it takes to reach the mainstream.

> ***"The future of technology will be built by those who refuse to accept the world as it is and dare to imagine it as it could be."***

NOW GO BREAK THE PATTERN.

#WTMIWD20#BreakThePatter

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By Women Techmakers Nsukka . IWD 2026

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BREAK THE PATTERN

WOMEN SHAPING THE FUTURE OF TECH

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

WITH GRATITUDE

By Patricia Oko

This book would not exist without the courage of the women who agreed to share their stories. Telling the truth is not always comfortable. Doing it in print, for the world to read, requires a particular kind of bravery. We are endlessly grateful to each of our contributors.

To the organising team behind IWD 2026 in Nsukka, thank you for creating the kind of space where a book like this could be born and celebrated.

To Chidinma Ukaegbu, thank you for lending your voice and your vision to these pages.

To the designers, editors, and proofreaders who helped bring this book to life, thank you for your craft.

And to the community of women in tech across Nigeria, Africa, and the world who have been building, breaking patterns, and showing up - this is for you.

IWD 202. Break the Patter

Women Techmakers Nsukka

FROM THE MARGINS TO THE MAINSTREAM

Women Who Claimed Their Seat at the Table of Technology. They were told the room was full. They walked in anyway. From the Margins to the Mainstream is a powerful collection of true stories told by women who navigated bias, made radical career pivots, built businesses from nothing, mentored the next generation, and rose to lead in one of the world's most male-dominated industries: technology.

Rooted in Africa and reaching across the globe, these stories celebrate the women who refused to accept that tech was not for them. Their journeys are honest, inspiring, and ultimately transformative not just for the women who lived them, but for every reader who picks up this book.

In a world that has too often written women out of the technology story, From the Margins to the Mainstream writes them back in boldly, unapologetically, and on their own terms.

#WTMIWD2026 #BreakThePattern